

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

Anwar Ali is a happy, healthy 12-year-old, naughty and prone to nattering, quite the boy next door. It's difficult to imagine he would ever run away from home. Yet, till a few months ago, he was just one of the 200 children who go missing at railway platforms in India every single day. What happens to them? Where do they come

guarding TRACKS

✱ **Pramod Kulkarni, 53**

Project Rescuing destitute children from railway platforms

Can-do Icon Vijay Mahajan, an IIM-A alumni, who inspired him to take up developmental projects

70 children reach the platforms of Mumbai railway station every day. The number is **35** for Delhi.



from and where do they go? These are the questions that have been plaguing 53-year-old Pramod Kulkarni for the last two decades. "New Delhi alone sees more than 35 children arriving at its platforms every day. For Mumbai, it's double that figure," says Kulkarni, founder of Sathi, an institution that rescues children from railway platforms. Last year, Sathi rescued close to 4,000 children from platforms, of which more than 2,000 were reunited with their families. It's a big leap since 2002, when 700 children were rescued. One such lucky child is Anwar whose parents had been frantically searching for him.

The volunteers of Sathi monitor railway platforms every day from 8 a.m. to 11 p.m. to look for many more like Anwar. "You have to make the children feel that they are part of the society," says Kulkarni. The volunteers take these children to the movies, eat together, talk to them and when their confidence is won, bring them to the Sathi shelters. Kulkarni's dream organisation today has a presence in 22 locations across the country where it works independently or

with partners. The families of these runaway children are tracked down, contacted and in the case of children like Anwar, there is a happy ending as well, where the child is reunited with the family to live happily ever after. "We have a very unique situation in India as the family is the most important unit of our society. Most families, no matter how poor they are, want to keep their children," he says. This is why Sathi believes that reuniting the child with the family is the most logical completion of this circle.

The idea of working with children on railway platforms came to Kulkarni in 1992. "I first saw similar work being done by SNV at the University in Pune. While working with underprivileged children is a vast and never-ending process, I felt we needed more focus and decided to work in this specific direction," he says. After graduating from Dharwad, Kulkarni had completed his M.A. in statistics from Baroda and taught in Ahmedabad, for two years, before he secured admission to the same institute in 1979. In 1985, Kulkarni joined a new venture called Pradhan in the development s

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